SURPRISE (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Surprise models the tactical edge of an ambush. In the 2024 rules, a surprised creature no longer loses its turn: it only suffers **Disadvantage** on its **Initiative** roll. This avoids freezing a character for a whole turn, while keeping the narrative impact of the ambush.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. The DM determines who notices the threat: a common method is the ambushers' **Stealth** check against the targets' **Passive Perception**. Table rule
2. Creatures that don't notice the threat are **surprised**.
3. They roll Initiative with **Disadvantage**.
4. Once the order is set, everyone acts normally on their turn.

⚠ Good to know:

- Surprise is **individual**: a creature can be surprised even if its allies are not.
- Advantage and Disadvantage cancel: a surprised character who also has Advantage rolls a single d20.
- **Change from 2014**: the **Alert** feat no longer makes you unsurprisable. See the **Initiative** sheet for its current effect.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

A "surprised" character can still act before their attacker because of a good roll (the surprised guard reacts before the hidden archer). It can feel inconsistent.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe this quick reaction as an instinctive reflex (the guard jumps and draws at once), or stress the shooter's clumsiness (the archer hesitates for a moment).

Step 1 – Determine alertness: Table rule

The DM judges whether creatures are attentive:

- **Ambushing characters**: they use Stealth against their targets' Passive Perception.
- **Alerted targets**: if they expect danger (an alarm sounded, an obvious noise), they are not surprised.

Step 2 – Identify surprised creatures:

A creature is surprised if it doesn't notice its attackers before combat begins, for example because it fails against the attackers' Stealth check. A creature can be surprised even if its allies are not.

Step 3 – Effect on Initiative:

Surprise gives **Disadvantage** on the Initiative roll.

Example: goblins ambush from the bushes. The unaware adventurers roll Initiative with Disadvantage.

Step 4 – Start of combat:

- Every creature, surprised or not, enters the Initiative order normally.
- A creature is not denied its action on the first turn (unlike 2014).
- Surprise only slows its entry, via Disadvantage on the Initiative roll.

Step 5 – Exceptions and special rules:

- **Incapacitated** (asleep, paralyzed, unconscious, etc.): Disadvantage on Initiative, even without surprise.
- **Invisible** when rolling: Advantage on Initiative.
- **Alert feat**: adds the Proficiency Bonus to Initiative. It no longer protects from surprise.
- **Class features**: some improve Initiative, for example Barbarian level 7 – Feral Instinct (Advantage).

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Readying an action

You can't delay your turn: you act or you ready an action. A readied action isn't a commitment: you can drop it for an Opportunity Attack, but you have only one Reaction per round.

Hidden, invisible, found

A hidden creature has the Invisible condition, which ends when a creature finds it. Blindsight and Truesight reveal it.

Hiding again

After attacking, you need the Hide action to hide again, unless you have a special ability.

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